such situations, an outside power that truly has the interests of the people at heart can effect a change that the people themselves cannot manage easily. Without foreign intervention, the Franco dictatorship in Spain lasted forty years. By contrast, military defeat brought Mussolini's and Hitler's regimes to a quicker end. If the United States can overthrow a bloody dictator like Saddam Hussein in the space of weeks and free his people, why not do it? This logic would favour an intervention in every dictatorial country, from Cuba to North Korea, from Venezuela to Zaire, constrained only by crass budgetary constraints.

Overthrowing a dictator, however, is only the first and easiest step toward building a democracy. If the United States simply left Iraq at this point after holding elections, or with a puppet government in place, there would be little to safeguard the Iraqi people from the emergence of a new tyrant. Countries do not fall prey to dictatorial regimes simply because of bad luck. Such countries often have power structures in place that facilitate dictatorships: typically, dictators are the face of a narrow elite, which has captured both political and economic power. Change is possible only if the power structure is changed and becomes more broad-based. Without that, any political revolution will only replace the old tyrants with new ones.

Japan is often mentioned as a successful example of democracy imposed by outside forces. The origins of that success, however, have to be found in the sweeping reforms imposed by Douglas MacArthur. Before his reforms, land holdings in Japan were concentrated and economic power was held by a few large industrial and financial combines called the Zaibatsus. MacArthur saw these agrarian and industrial elites gave backbone to the Japanese Nationalist government, which had taken Japan to war. For this reason, he tried to undermine their power. The post-war land reforms did expand and